



A forum conversation on a Coursera lecture administered by Stanford University

links, videos, more links and directives. Instead of getting a straightforward answer, you're left with an array of options from which to choose. You're even more confused than when you started out! In situations like these, you need either a one-on-one session with a guide or a brainstorming session with real brains, not virtual ones.

The word “massive” as a part of the acronym MOOC suggests the presence of a large body of users. Somewhere between those massive number of students there's bound to be an acute shortage of student-instructor interaction. This glaring lack of a personal touch is one of the biggest drawbacks of MOOCs. Online forums for discussions are undoubtedly helpful sometimes, but an online discussion is only sufficient for close-ended subjects like Mathematics at best. Subjects like Art and Political Science rely heavily on open-ended discussion and debate. It's hard to have a fruitful debate when you can't see the face of the person with whom you're interacting and are compelled to use dialogue bubbles for a rebuttal. Virtual interaction is still a long way away from replicating the benefits of actual social interaction.

Inefficient feedback

Any learning is cemented only when a student learns from his mistakes and recognises his strengths. Drawing analogy from any control system, a student can only improve if he receives regular feedback regarding his progress and manages to rectify mistakes. Feedback systems are irrelevant when we talk about online learning portals that consist of assimilated course